

without amassing debt, and they acquired specific concrete skills that made their résumés unique and showed just how resourceful they were. Did it work? You bet! They're currently working in their dream jobs. Today, they field emails from their penniless writer friends with MFAs begging for freelance work because they can't get hired anywhere!

Here's my philosophy: if you're a creative person, great. Give your creativity an entrepreneurial boost and game the system to your benefit. It's really that simple.

Money Mistake: *You Think You're Too Smart to Be an Intern*

The Fix: *Pay Your Dues*

This may surprise you, but I'm in favor of internships, paid or unpaid. If you can get inside a large organization so they can road test your abilities, great—that is a form of payment in the long run. If you apply for an internship and are lucky enough to get hired, work as if you're getting paid \$10,000 a week. The interning experience may have immense benefit in the future, whether this company hires you on as a full-time employee or gives you the recommendation you need to land a lucrative position somewhere else.

How do you pay for your life while you're working for free? Go out and get a job. You didn't expect me to endorse going into credit card debt, did you? If you're an unpaid intern, you'll need to make pizza or sling beer at a restaurant. You also need to set a limit on how long you'll work for free. I suggest one year. If you're not offered a permanent job with financial compensation within 12 months, you're probably not going to get one. Time to move on.

Last summer, Savannah was offered two internships with companies she really wanted to work with. Linda and I agreed this was a great opportunity; it was exactly the sort of experience Savannah needed to be competitive in her industry. But she would also need to juggle a job to help pay her way. The three of us sat down together and decided that Savannah would intern during the